largely seen to support the BJP, and the latter are deemed the RJD's preserve. Fortunately, the couple had the support of Rahul's father, a state government employee. They also have state backing—the Nitish Kumar government sees inter-caste marriages as a tool to break the well-entrenched caste barriers in the state. The one-time grant of Rs 1 lakh, offered as a fixed deposit that can be withdrawn only after three years, has been given to 882 couples in the past three years. All that an inter-caste couple has to do to be eligible is to get their marriage registered. Not all of them do, of course. Still, the scheme does send out a significant message in a society where it is commonly believed that "daughters and votes" should not go outside one's own caste group.



TIES OF LOVE
Rahul, a Bhumihar, and Seema, a Yadav, married in June 2020

Photographs by RANJAN RAHI

Such an attitude is not unique to Bihar, of course. A survey by the US-based Pew Research Center, involving 30,000 face-to-face interviews conducted across India in 17 languages between late 2019 and early 2020, had 64 per cent of the respondents saying it was important to stop women of their community from marrying people of other castes. Not that anyone claims same-caste marriages are some sort of idyllic affair—witness the 1,000+ cases of dowry deaths that Bihar records every year. Almost all such cases were reported from traditional marriages that followed caste rules, say police officers. In fact, Bihar accounted for 1,047 (almost 15 per cent) of the 7,045 cases of dowry deaths all over India in 2020, according to the latest National Crime Records Bureau data.

There's another statistic that one can counterpose against that—this relates to cases of kidnapping for marriages, most of which, according to a senior police officer, actually involve inter-caste couples running away to get married in the face of social opposition. In 2021, as many as 4,041 such cases were registered in Bihar—almost 40 per cent of the total 10,205 abduction cases in the state that year. "The woman's parents force us to file a case of abduction when she goes missing. In fact, these cases indicate how inter-caste couples are revolting against the rigid caste barriers," says the officer. And the revolution is webcast. Not a week seems to pass without a courageous young inter-caste couple posting a video on Facebook, affirming that they married of their own free will.

NOT A WEEK SEEMS TO PASS WITHOUT AN INTER-CASTE COUPLE 'COMING OUT' ON VIDEO

Sociologists believe social mobility, coupled with the ubiquity of social media, is slowly weakening the caste system. Though the official numbers remain small, it's a clearly perceptible trend that goes beyond urban Bihar. An official of the social welfare department concedes the real numbers could be much higher than those indicated by the number of couples coming forward to avail of the government's grant. "This is because many of these couples have to fight against society and caste leaders, besides sceptical parents, which forces them to go into hiding instead of approaching the government. But things are surely changing," he says.

Though still a speck in Bihar's social universe, inter-caste couples do come across as agents of change. And they have the support of CM Nitish Kumar. On February 22, he felicitated Rahul Manjhi and Babita Paswan in Jamui district, handing them a cheque of Rs 1 lakh and calling them exemplars of an "ideal marriage" that reflects the "reform" sweeping across society. (Rahul and Babita, strikingly, are both Dalit but still had to fight off strict endogamy rules.) In November 2017, he had visited the home of another inter-caste couple. His state-wide campaign against dowry, too, has got some positive response, with Hridyanath Singh, a teacher in Bhojpur district, returning Rs 4 lakh to the bride's family from whom he had taken the amount as dowry.

Bihar's reformist scheme differs from the Centre's version, in which Rs 2.5 lakh is given to couples if either the bride or the groom is from a Scheduled Caste. According to the Union social justice ministry's annual report for '20-21, Bihar has not asked for any central assistance for incentives to such marriages. There were 18,522 beneficiaries of the central scheme across the country in 2020-21. Karnataka topped the list with 5,200 beneficiaries, followed by Maharashtra with 3,712 and West Bengal with 1,500. An official concedes that it's likely not many marriages have taken place in Bihar where only one of the partners is from a Dalit caste. This could be the next barrier Nitish's push for social reform through inter-caste marriages would have to break. ■